

There is an India that continues to be feted at global high tables as a regional power blessed with a robust civil society. It is also the least controlled marketplace in the East, and an irresistible destination in the so-called flat world. Its best and the brightest—whether from politics, business or science—are in the global front row of achievement. The modernisation project of India that began with Jawaharlal Nehru has now its 21st century face in Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, whose ascent to power essays how merit and opportunity can make one of the greatest success stories of our times. Then, there is the other India, that infernal land without justice, where your identity is defined not by your profession or your talent but by your caste. India is a country of a thousand castes, and they are the foundation on which social structures are built, certainly in the countryside. And this is where desperate politics plays out its salvation script. The politics of social justice, whose masters thrive in places like Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and Tamil Nadu, is sustained by the electoral profitability of caste. The Mandal Commission was the most blatant instrument of social engineering, but V.P. Singh's successors were not anyway better: they all worked hard to make India one of the most reserved countries on earth. Now we have the caste-based Census 2011, endorsed by the moderniser prime minister, and bound to further accelerate the social Balkanisation of India. Caste doesn't mean national damnation, but its political exploitation does. Welcome to the caste country.

POLITICS Divide and Rule

| By Priya Sahgal |

When Prime Minister Manmohan Singh announced in the Lok Sabha on the last day of the Budget Session that the Cabinet would soon take an "appropriate decision" on the demand for a caste-based census, the loudest thumping of desks came neither from the treasury nor from the Opposition benches. It was the trio of Mulayam Singh Yadav, Lalu Prasad Yadav and Sharad Yadav, part-time friends, part-time foes now turned strategic allies, who thanked the prime minister first and then Sonia Gandhi. The show of gratitude to the UPA chairperson wasn't misplaced as the decision to include caste in Census 2011 could not have been taken without Sonia's go-ahead, especially when the UPA Cabinet itself was divided on the issue. The differences were there for all to see when earlier the same day Home Minister P. Chidambaram stated in Parliament that "members who said caste is a reality also acknowledged that caste is a divisive factor". Yet, just a few hours later, the finance minister and the Government's chief strategist Pranab Mukherjee told reporters outside the Parliament that "caste will be included in

the present census." Such is the political compulsion of this Government that the pressure from a group of 45 MPs, belonging to the Samajwadi Party, the JD(U) and the RJD was enough to make it succumb meekly. This despite the fact that Chidambaram was evasive in his assurance to Parliament. However, after a meeting with the Yadav troika, the Government did a sudden U-turn with Mukherjee's and Manmohan's statements on the very same day.

The sudden UPA-Yadav bonhomie fooled none. The recent vote on the Opposition-sponsored cut motions had made the Government all too aware that its safety lay in numbers. Mamata Banerjee's unpredictable ways and the DMK's insatiable appetite for more had made the Congress floor managers more amenable to the Yadav—particularly Mulayam's—sentiments. In turn, Lalu and Mulayam supported the Nuclear Liability Bill when it was tabled. It's a very cosy club where every-

one is striking deals to ensure survival, yet some Congress leaders worry that they could walk into a political minefield called Mandal-II. There has been no caste-based census since 1931. The practice brought in by the British was later discontinued as it was found to be "divisive". The lack of authentic figures have been a problem for various government welfare and reservation policies. Patna-based social researcher Shaibal Gupta points out that the 1931 figures are outdated as "some castes have become extinct while others have

18, 40

is the number of
categories of
Scheduled Castes
and Tribes listed by
the last census
held in 2001.